



Neighbours **CHINA**

growth. Every Chinese leader since Mao Tse Tung knows the significance of keeping the country's peasantry happy. Mao realised early enough during his famed Long March that it was the peasant and not just the industrial worker who would be the driving force of the Communist revolution sweeping across China. After the Communist Party of China came to power in 1949, Mao, in a bid to retain state control over agriculture, took away all hereditary rights from individuals over land, formed repressive communes and centralised agricultural production.

It was Deng Xiaoping though who set China on the path to radical reform with his brand of command capitalism that considerably freed up the economy to market forces and aggressively pursued global trade as a means of overcoming national poverty. Deng changed the face of rural China too by lessening state control over agriculture and allowing peasants to head to cities and find jobs in factories or set up rural enterprises and profit from them.

Now the new collegiate leadership under Hu—the country seems done with personality-based helmsmen—wants to usher in a revolution in rural China by unleashing a long term programme of agricultural and land reforms. Apart from a 30-year lease ownership on their property, Chinese peasants can now rent or lease out land to others, enabling consolidation of farm holdings and improving agricultural productivity. Also, they are free to set up industries especially agro-based ones, on their land or lease them out to corporate entities and earn profits.

Meanwhile, the Chinese Government seems to be successfully negotiating the global meltdown with a \$400-billion stimulus programme that is likely to see the economy grows at a healthy 9 per cent. But Hu's other main problem is dealing with rising political dissent in the country's extremes fuelled by ethnic tensions and gross disparities in income. In the Muslim-dominated Xinjiang province, where the Uighurs unleashed a wave of violence against Han Chinese, things are coming to a boil because of the decades of suppression and discrimination. In Tibet, which saw widespread riots last year that the Government brutally put down, the situation continues to be volatile and can easily erupt. Along with rising inequities among the rural populace in other provinces, these are dangerous portents for China.

So far the Chinese Government has handled the crisis with what one

diplomat calls, "the crouching tiger, hidden dragon" approach. Now even as the Government's iron hand is visible more often than not, it is sheathing it in a velvet glove. There is a far more savvy approach to managing public opinion. With close to 338 million Internet users, 100 million blogs, 2,169 newspapers, 2,900 radio stations, 420 television stations and three lakh new titles of books published annually, the monolithic Chinese opinion is a thing of the past.

Even senior Chinese leaders are aware of the new power of the media and are keen to channelise it in their favour. Qian Xiaoqian, the affable vice-minister of the powerful State Council Information Office, says that a few years ago they would have great difficulty in getting ministers to address the press. Today, there is a clamour by every ministry to hold regular press conferences by their minister and hour-long chats over the Internet. Says Qian, "All of them have realised that they cannot escape the media so they have decided to learn how to deal with it."

The Government is now conscious of the importance of public opinion and an oft-quoted Chinese phrase in Beijing these days is, "Remember the ocean that the ship sails on

RIISING NATIONALISM HAS SEEN CHINA

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**CHINESE BORDER NEGOTIATOR
DAI BINGGUO WITH PRIME MINISTER
MANMOHAN SINGH IN DELHI RECENTLY**

is the same ocean that swallows it up". Increasingly, the media is being freed up to expose corruption and report on the success or failure of major projects. While accusing top party leaders is still regarded as blasphemy (unless, of course, there is official sanction) whacking lower level bureaucrats and party officials accused of corruption has the Government's tacit approval. Li Xing, assistant editor-in-chief, *China Daily*, the country's largest circulated English newspaper, says, "In terms of coverage, we have become bolder rather than restrained. We do not shy away from

“ Ministers and officials have realised that they cannot escape the media so they have decided to learn how to deal with it. There is a new openness in the government. ”

QIAN XIAOQIAN
Vice Minister,
State Council
for Information



“ In terms of coverage, the Chinese media has become bolder rather than restrained. My paper does not shy away from bad news and is the first to report on disasters. ”

LI XING,
Assistant
Editor-in-Chief,
China Daily

